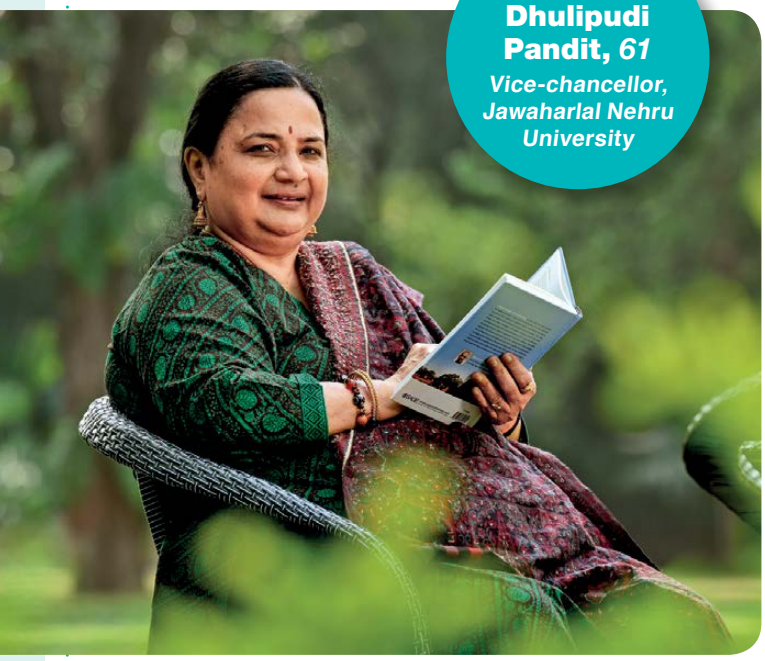
RAJWANT RAWAT



Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit, *61*
Vice-chancellor, Jawaharlal Nehru University

Alma Matters

ACCOMPLISHMENT
As JNU's first woman V-C, she is trying to heal a bruised campus

AN ALUMNA OF THE INSTITUTION, Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit took over as the vice-chancellor of Jawaharlal Nehru University in February 2022, at a time when her predecessor M. Jagadesh Kumar had left the bastion of Left politics bruised by his attempts to change its very character. Violence entered a campus that was known for its culture of intellectual debate and discussion. What better then than to get someone who had passed through its portals to head JNU?

It didn't stop the furore over her partiality for a right-wing narrative, but that never quite overshadowed her very notable accomplishment—of being the first woman vice-chancellor of JNU, and from beyond elite caste horizons to boot.

If the old saying puts a woman behind every successful man, in Santishree's case, it was the other way round. "I was raised as a single child by a single parent—my father. He not only cultivated in me an interest in academics but also taught me many valuable lessons on how to be a woman in a man's world. One of them was to work very hard because it is a struggle where there is a gender bias," she says. Born in St Petersburg in Russia in 1962 to author-journalist-turned-civil servant Dr Dhulipudi Anjaneyulu and Tamil and Telugu professor Mulamoodi Adilakshmi, her parents, she says, were extremely liberal for their time, having themselves had an inter-caste marriage. "My mother was a Brahmin and my father was from an economically backward caste," she adds.

She had wanted to become a neurologist and even got admission in AIIMS Delhi. But girls in medicine at that time were mostly encouraged to become gynaecologists, which she didn't want. So, she dropped out and studied history and politics at Presidency College in Chennai instead. It was on to the School of International Relations in JNU for an MPhil and PhD, and a teaching job at Goa University thereafter. She was serving as a professor of political science at Savitribai Phule University in Pune when she was appointed JNU V-C.

It has been two years now. She considers her most important achievement to be the fact that she brought peace back to the campus. "We didn't have a single violent or disruptive protest on campus over Israel and Hamas. Instead, the issue was debated and discussed on our lawns. That line between critical thinking and respecting differences is one that is important for harmony," she says. And she is doing her utmost to bring that back to her alma mater. ■

-Sonali Acharjee

HER PERSONAL CREDO

"Don't let anyone diminish your ambitions, independence and dreams"

CHANGE OF ADDRESS
When she joined, administrative papers submitted to her were still addressed 'in his authority'. "I had to really put my foot down for it to be changed to 'in her authority'"